Game Pitch Proposal: Kaudi (Cowrie Shell Game)

Centurion University of Technology and Management (CUTM)
Native & Indigenous Sports of India Collection — Title 18

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1. Cover Page

- **Title of Project**: Kaudi: The Ancient Cowrie Dice & Scoring Game
- **Project Type**: Digital Preservation & Casual Strategy Board Game
- **Development Team**: Centurion University Heritage Games Studio (Swarup & Engineering Team)
- **Lead Designer**: Abhi Mitra (Head of Design, CUTM)
- **Academic Reference**: *An Anthology of Native & Indigenous Sports of India* (CUTM, 2025)
- **Target Platforms**: WebGL (Desktop & Mobile Browser / PWA), Android (AAB), iOS (iPadOS/TestFlight)
- **Date**: September 2026

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2. Executive Summary

Kaudi brings one of humanity's oldest gaming instruments—the polished cowrie shell (*Cypraea moneta*)—into the modern digital era. Long before cubical numbered dice were standardized, Indian civilizations across millennia cast handfuls of natural cowrie shells onto woven mats, reading their landing orientations (toothed mouth-up vs. smooth convex dorsal) to determine fortunes, race movements, and scoring tallies. As both a standalone high-stakes scoring contest and the shared random-number generator engine for epic traditional games like *Ashtapada*, *Chauka Bara*, and *Pachisi*, Kaudi captures the raw, physical joy of traditional Indian board play.

Designed under the strict Centurion University Design Bible, the game features warm hand-carved teakwood surfaces, woven coir mats, tactile shell physics, and authentic acoustic Foley recordings. Players can engage in rapid 5-to-10 minute matches against a risk-calculating heuristic AI or with friends via local pass-and-play. With dual game modes—a straightforward **Classic Target Race** and an adrenaline-fueled **Press-Your-Luck** mode—

Kaudi balances instant accessibility with genuine statistical depth, offering players worldwide a direct, interactive connection to India’s living cultural heritage.

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3. Game Description

a. Overview

At its heart, Kaudi is a fast, tactical scoring race for 2 to 4 players. Players take turns shaking and tossing a set of natural cowrie shells (commonly 4, 6, or 7 shells) onto the game arena. Each shell that lands mouth-up scores points, while rare configurations—such as all shells landing mouth-up (*Chamma*) or all shells landing mouth-down (*Ashtam*)—yield massive bonus points and grant free extra rolls. The primary quest is simple yet fiercely competitive: be the first player to accumulate the target score (default 100 points) and claim the title of Master of Kaudi.

b. The Quest

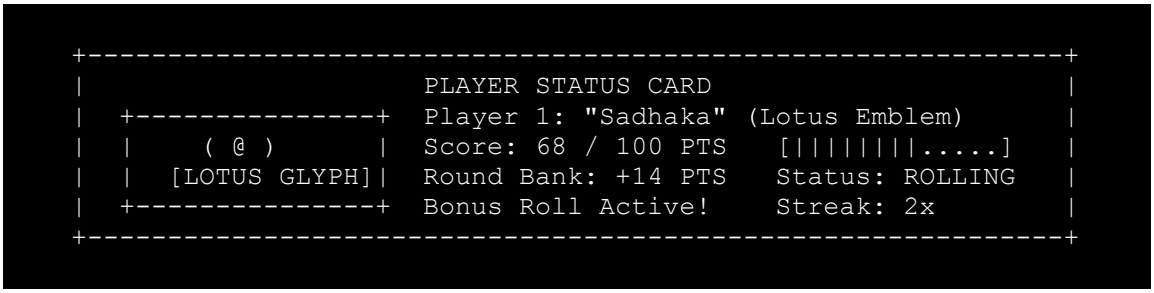
- **Main Objective**: Race to reach or exceed the target threshold (configurable to 50, 100, or 150 points) before your opponents.
- **Obstacles & Friction**:
  - *Variance of the Toss*: Inherent probability dynamics mean that low scores (1 or 2 points) are common, while high-value throws require patience and luck.
  - *Press-Your-Luck Hazards (Bust Condition)*: In Press-Your-Luck mode, rolling a round without scoring or rolling a zero-mouth configuration resets your unbanked round score to zero.
  - *Dynamic AI Competition*: As opponents approach the finish line, they adjust their risk thresholds, placing psychological pressure on the human player to gamble on extra throws.
- **Rewards & Progression**:
  - Rolling special configurations awards celebratory visual VFX, resounding victory stings, and immediate extra throws.
  - Victorious matches unlock higher AI difficulties, detailed cultural historical lore cards, and custom traditional shell finishes (porcelain white, tiger cowrie, polished brass).

c. Main Character (The Player & Avatars)

Players take on the role of traditional Indian court and village gamers. Rather than controlling an artificial fantasy protagonist, the player's presence is represented through:

- **Player Avatars / Glyphs**: Hand-illustrated circular tokens featuring classical Indian motifs (Lotus, Royal Elephant, Sacred Bull, Royal Peacock, Sun Chakra).
- **Player Attributes**: Live running score tally, active turn highlight aura, and an unbanked risk meter.
- **Perspective**: Top-down isometric perspective directly overlooking the wooden rolling tray and woven cloth arena.

d. Sketch of Main Character / Token Layout



e. Opponents (AI System)

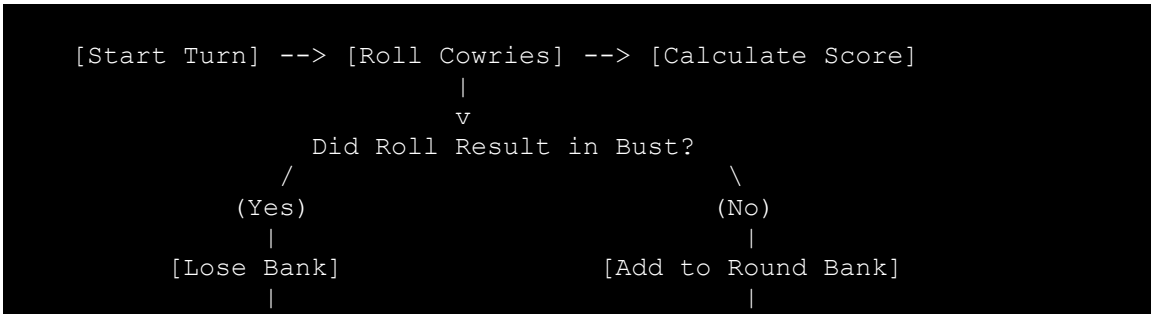
The single-player experience pits the player against an algorithmic AI opponent named **"Chanakya"** (Heuristic Solver):

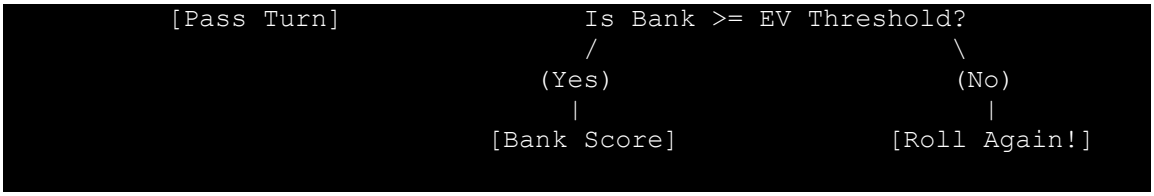
- **Behavior Logic**: The AI operates on Expected Value (EV) calculation. Before every roll in Press-Your-Luck mode, it evaluates:

$$\text{EV} = P(\text{safe roll}) \times \text{Expected Gain} - P(\text{bust}) \times \text{Current Bank}$$

- **Personalities & Difficulties**:
  - *Gramin (Easy)*: Extremely conservative; banks points as soon as it reaches 8–10 points; ignores opponent score.
  - *Vyapari (Medium)*: Balanced mathematical threshold player; banks when round bank exceeds 14 points.
  - *Raja (Hard)*: Race-aware aggressive strategist; calculates gap to leader and aggressively gambles on bonus rolls when falling behind.

f. Sketch of Opponent Architecture



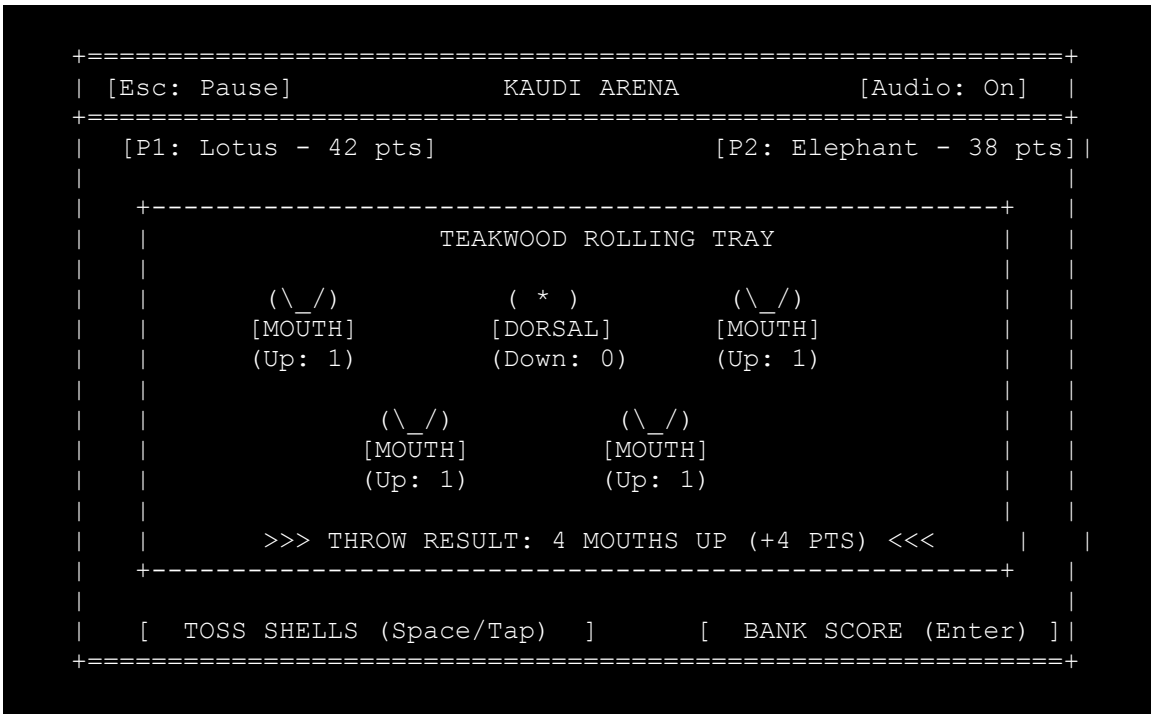


g. Environment

The game is staged within a serene, timeless Indian courtyard during the golden hour:

- **The Rolling Tray**: Deeply polished teakwood frame (`#5A3919`) lined with hand-woven natural coir matting (`#EBDBC0`).
- **Lighting & Atmosphere**: Warm, directional sunlight creating soft drop-shadows beneath each shell, evoking the tactile feel of an outdoor verandah in Odisha or Rajasthan.
- **Cultural Grounding**: Sandstone borders, block-printed borders, and engraved geometric mandalas inspired by temple architecture.

h. Sketch of Game Arena / World



i. Menus

- **Splash / Title Screen**: Majestic Kaudi title in Tiro Devanagari Hindi font, framed by traditional brass oil lamps.
- **Game Options Screen**:
  - Player Count: 1P vs AI, 2 Players, 3 Players, 4 Players.

    - Shell Configuration: 4 Shells (Fast/Casual), 6 Shells (Authentic Traditional), 7 Shells (Chauka Bara Standard).
    - Game Mode: Classic Race vs. Press-Your-Luck.
    - Target Points: 50, 100, or 150 points.
- **Settings & Lore Screen**: Volume sliders, language selection (English, Hindi, Odia), and an illustrated history modal.

j. Controls & Ergonomics

- **Touch (Mobile/Tablet)**: Direct full-finger tap anywhere on the tray to toss; oversized buttons (minimum 88x88px) for Bank and Roll.
- **Mouse (Desktop Web)**: Left-click on buttons or click-and-drag toss gesture in the tray.
- **Keyboard**: Spacebar to Toss, Enter/B to Bank, Escape to Pause/Settings.
- **Feedback**: Tactile haptic vibration on mobile devices upon shell impact and score resolution.

k. Sounds & Acoustic Identity

- **Foley Effects**: Pristine, organic recordings of real marine cowrie shells rattling inside cupped palms, scattering across cloth, and clicking crisply against wood.
- **Interface Audio**: Soft wooden block taps, brass bell chime on bonus throws, and subtle hand-drum beats on turn changes.
- **Music Soundtrack**: Low-intensity, meditative Indian classical acoustic arrangement with Bansuri (bamboo flute) and gentle Tanpura/Sitar drones.

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4. Summary & Sales Pitch

Why Kaudi?
In a market saturated with generic digital dice rollers and Western board clones, **Kaudi** stands apart as an authentic, tactile celebration of Indian indigenous gaming heritage. It fulfills two vital roles simultaneously:

1. **A Standalone Hit**: It is an addictive, lightning-fast casual game with deep psychological tension in Press-Your-Luck mode that appeals across generations—from grandchildren on smartphones to elders familiar with courtyard games.

2. **The Backbone of an 18-Game Collection**: It delivers the proven, deterministic dice physics engine that directly powers Centurion University's entire 18-title indigenous games suite.

Zero loading bloat, instant cross-platform browser accessibility, and museum-grade cultural fidelity make **Kaudi** an indispensable showcase of traditional Indian sports in the digital era.